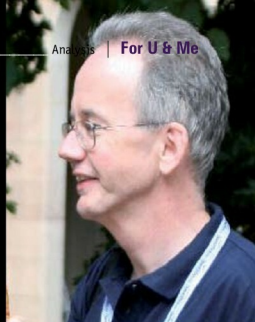


"Oracle is a big player in the enterprise software market, and just like Microsoft, once it gets one product to a customer, it will try and use that installation as a lever to get other products in. Up till now, those at Oracle haven't made a serious attack on the desktop space. Maybe OpenOffice.org will give them an incentive to do so."

—John McCreesh, marketing product lead, OpenOffice.org



been shown before in the open source world that name changes of products can be done quickly. Just look at how quickly Firefox was adopted. The reason for being able to change quickly is that MySQL is a product mainly used by developers. Developers are quick to find and go with new trends, and if one fork gets a lot of attraction from the community it can take over very quickly."

If Oracle realises the benefits of MySQL and boosts its development to capture new markets, it would be the best for the community and the customers. In case it fails to do so, customers don't have to worry; there will always be a fork ready.

OpenOffice.org: The road to independence

OpenOffice.org (OOo) is one product that may not seem to fit in Oracle's game plan, and thus might have a hard time under the database giant's umbrella. John McCreesh, marketing project lead, OpenOffice.org, has this to say,

"IBM already has its own commercial OpenOffice.org derivative, so it has a clear financial interest in keeping the project going as long as there is an active body of developers working on it. IBM is better known than Oracle in OpenOffice.org circles."

But, an office suite is a product that is an absolute, basic requirement for any enterprise. It also ensures penetration into new segments. Heavy deployments at big enterprises as well as government agencies mean huge revenues. This has been Microsoft's bread and butter for ages. IBM and Novell both realise this and that's why they have their own OOo derivatives—Lotus Symphony and GOCO, respectively.

Oracle knows this only too well. An office suite was one important component missing from making Oracle the Apple of the enterprise world. So, the estimation is that Oracle might try to optimise OOo for its Oracle Collaborative and e-Business suites. The level of integration could go as high as

pulling data from the Oracle backend database into OOo components, thus offering newer solutions to its customers.

This may seem a bit out of focus, but Microsoft is Oracle's archrival and an office suite is an important part of Microsoft's backbone. Oracle may not let go of an opportunity to annoy Microsoft and dig into its market. Apple also depends heavily on third-party office suite applications, so a polished version will only mean constant flow of money for Oracle. If Oracle makes a mistake here, OOo will be forked by the community and be adopted by either IBM or Novell, and the potential market will slip from Oracle's hands. But, considering the support Oracle offered for ODF (Open Document Format—an ISO standard for office document formats, and the default used in OOo), it is hard to believe that Oracle will let go of a potentially lucrative market.

"Oracle is a big player in the

A culture shock for Sun developers at Oracle

Sun was known as an open source company, but Oracle doesn't have that reputation. But according to Lachal, "Oracle will definitely be a culture shock for the people at Sun, but that has not much to do with open source (and again I need to repeat that Oracle is not new to open source at all—open source is, indeed, very small in the grand scheme of Oracle things, but Oracle is better placed to make money out of it than Sun). The two companies had a very different culture—one rather laid back and, from a software point

of view, not particularly effective; while the other is very aggressive, pragmatic and much more effective (but, I suspect much less fun)."

Tiemann adds, "Oracle has been contributing to the Linux kernel for quite some time, and they get no special treatment—good or bad—from that community. If you are talking about Sun's engineering teams now reporting to Oracle managers, I'm sure that differences in management/leadership style will be a shock for some and not for others."